STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE				AU-12300
	SARPY COUNTY SHERIFF'S OFFICE PAPILLION * NEBRASKA **GREG LONDON** **SHERIFF**	DATE ISSUED **05/23/24**	DATE REVISED	DATE REVIEWED 02/02/25
		APPROVED: *GREG LONDON*		
CHAPTER TITLE AUXILIARY UNITS: PEER SUPPORT UNIT		RESOURCES		
SUBJECT PEER SUPPORT UNIT OPERATIONS AND TRAINING		CROSS-REFERENCE		

I. Purpose:

The purpose of this policy is to establish guidelines for the Peer Support Unit.

II. Policy:

The Sarpy County Sheriff's Office Peer Support Unit shall provide trained Peer Support Employees to personnel or family members who request or potentially need assistance. The Peer Support Program is designed to augment employee assistance programs, but not replace them. Peer Support Employees shall refer cases that require professional intervention to appropriate experts. It is beneficial for Peer Support Employees to be involved in supporting individuals involved in critical incidents such as officer-involved shootings or other incidents.

III. Procedures:

A. Philosophy:

1. Peer Support Employee, sworn or non-sworn, is a specifically trained colleague, not a therapist.

2. Within limits of confidentially, Peer Support Employees will not be asked to give information about members they support.

3. Individuals may voluntarily choose or reject a Peer Support Employee's assistance.

4. The Peer Support Program is not an alternative to discipline. A Peer Support Employee does not intervene in the disciplinary process, even at a member's request.

B. Objectives:

1. To provide an additional support system for Sheriff's Office employees and their families.

2. Employees can seek assistance from a Peer Support Employee on their own accord and initiation.

3. Peer Support Employees can refer individuals to a variety of resources, including peer support programs from outside agencies that may be a better fit for the individual seeking help.

C. Administration:

1. The Peer Support Unit will be administrated by a designated program coordinator. The program coordinator may also be a Peer Support Employee in the program.

2. Peer Support Employees will attend formal instruction in peer support following their selection.

3. Peer Support Employees shall attend recurrent training and maintain appropriate certifications and memberships in appropriate support and professional organizations.

4. Peer Support Employees can consult with a mental health professional if available. Ideally, this consultation would be available 24 hours a day.

D. Confidentiality:

1. Peer Support Employees shall inform Sheriff's Office members when the limits of their confidentiality have been exceeded and consider potential role conflicts. These should be consistent with the law as well as Sheriff's Office policy and may include the following:

   a) Criminal law violations.

   b) When there is a concern, the employee presents a danger to themselves or others (e.g., threats of suicide, homicide, or felonious assault).

   c) Any other offenses that Nebraska Revised Statutes or Sheriff's Office Policies requires employees to report, including suspected sexual assault, domestic violence, or child/vulnerable adult abuse.

   d) When the disclosure is required by court order.

   e) When there is a serious and significant concern regarding the employee's

fitness for duty and there is a high risk to the safety of the employee, other Sheriff's Office employees, or the community.

2. Peer Support Employees must advise members that information told to them is not protected by legal privilege and that confidentiality is administratively provided and may not be recognized in court proceedings.

3. Peer Support Employees must not keep formal written or private records of supportive contacts. The only information that will be kept about peer support cases is the anonymous statistical information regarding the utilization of the peer support program.

E. Selection of Peer Support Employees:

1. Peer Support Employees will be selected through a formal application process, including interviews.

2. The following criteria may be considered in the selection of Peer Support Employees:

a) Good communications skills

b) Previous education and training

c) Resolved traumatic experiences

d) Maturity and good judgment

e) Personal and professional credibility

3. Peer Support Employees may also be de-selected from the program. Possible criteria include breach of confidentially, or failure to attend training.